

Civic Notices Platform

Strategic Meeting Report & Action Plan

Meeting with Nick Semper | November 2025

Executive Summary

What I'm Building: A digital platform that modernizes how legal notices (licensing applications, planning notices, road closures) are published and managed in the UK.

Why It Matters: The government is abolishing the 300-year-old requirement to publish notices in newspapers. Councils currently spend **£150,000+ per year** on newspaper advertising. My platform reduces this to essentially zero while improving public engagement and democratic transparency.

This Meeting: Nick Semper (experienced licensing consultant) is joining to help position the platform. He's sponsoring a major industry conference this week (2,500+ attendees) where he'll showcase my work to licensing officers, councillors, and legal professionals across the UK.

The Opportunity

Market Size

2,000-3,000 notices daily

50,000 active notices

350+ local authorities

Revenue Potential: Even capturing 10% of the market represents approximately **£3.6 million annual revenue** from applicant fees alone (before council subscriptions).

What Makes This Different

The existing solution (Public Notice Portal) just aggregates newspaper notices. When newspapers are no longer required, it becomes useless. My platform provides:

- **Direct Response Capability:** Public can submit objections/support directly through the platform
- **Council Management Portal:** Departments can build templates, manage representations, track analytics - all in one place
- **Complete Workflow:** Not just publication, but end-to-end case management
- **Analytics They Don't Have:** Councils literally don't know how many notices they process annually - I give them this data

Strategic Decisions Made

Pricing Strategy - Major Pivot

Decision: Offer the platform to councils **FOR FREE** initially (or first 10 adopters get lifetime free access).

Why:

- Adoption is make-or-break - if councils don't use it, the platform fails
- Creates a "no-brainer" decision for councils (save £150k/year with zero cost)
- Revenue comes from applicants (£49.99 per notice vs. current £400-600)

- After proving value, introduce minimal fees (e.g., £5/month per department)

Value Proposition by Audience

Audience	Key Benefit	Cost Impact
Councils	Centralized management, analytics, automated workflows	Save £150,000+/year on newspaper costs
Applicants (businesses)	Simple upload process, automatic validation, faster publication	£400-600 → £49.99 per notice
Public/Residents	Know what's happening nearby, easy objection submission	Free - improve local democracy

Immediate Opportunity: Industry Conference

Deadline: Tuesday (This Week)

Event: Institute of Licensing Annual Conference (2,500+ attendees)

Nick's Role: Sponsor and attendee - will showcase my platform to licensing officers, councillors, and legal professionals

What's Needed:

- Landing page with QR code (mobile-optimized for conference attendees)
- Short video (under 2 minutes) demonstrating the platform
- Three versions targeting councils, applicants, and public
- YouTube tracking to measure which councils engage

Why This Matters

Nick processes **350 licenses per year** with a **99.4% success rate**. He has deep relationships with the exact decision-makers who will adopt (or reject) my platform. This conference is the perfect opportunity to:

- Get early feedback from industry insiders
- Identify first 10 council adopters
- Build credibility through Nick's endorsement
- Gather business intelligence on competitors

Technical Improvements Needed

Legal Compliance Features (High Priority)

When someone objects to a licensing application, UK law requires them to specify which of the **four licensing objectives** their objection relates to:

1. Prevention of crime and disorder
2. Public nuisance
3. Public safety
4. Protection of children from harm (under 18)

Action: Add checkboxes for these objectives in the objection form. Support submissions (non-objections) just need a text box.

Key Features to Build

1. Council Analytics Dashboard

Councils don't know how many notices they process. When I asked the Head of Planning for North Yorkshire Council, he said: "I have no idea. I literally couldn't give you a number."

Opportunity: Provide them with data they've never had - notice volume, representation statistics, geographic trends, etc.

2. Blue Notice Photo Tracking

Nick's company posts physical "blue notices" on buildings (legal requirement). They photograph them as proof of compliance. This entire workflow should integrate into my platform - upload photos, timestamp them, generate proof-of-posting certificates.

3. Representation Management System

Councils need to review all objections/support submissions. Give them a proper inbox: filter by type, mark as reviewed, add internal notes, generate hearing reports.

4. Data Population from Council Websites

Legally, I can scrape council websites (not the Public Notice Portal). Estimated 50,000 active notices to import. This gives immediate value - the platform is useful from day one rather than starting empty.

5. Expand Beyond Licensing

Planning applications, road closures, traffic regulation orders, environmental permits - all use the same publication model. Each expansion multiplies the addressable market.

Business Model Validation

Why Councils Will Adopt

- **Cost Savings:** Westminster spends ~£132,000/year on newspaper ads. My platform costs them £0 initially.
- **Efficiency:** No more manual template building, no chasing newspapers for publication dates
- **Data They Don't Have:** Analytics on their own activity
- **Modernization:** Move away from "Victorian" newspaper notices to proper digital democracy
- **Future-Proof:** When newspaper requirement is abolished (likely in next 12-24 months), they're already set up

Why Applicants Will Pay £49.99

- **Massive Savings:** Current cost is £400-600 per newspaper notice
- **Simpler Process:** Upload PDF, platform extracts details via OCR, auto-validates
- **Faster:** No waiting for newspaper publication schedules
- **Compliance Built-In:** Automatic calculation of consultation periods, deadline reminders

Why the Public Will Use It

- **Free** to search and respond
- **Geographic Search:** See what's happening near you on a map
- **Easy Objections:** Submit representation directly rather than figuring out council contact details
- **Social Integration:** Share to Facebook community groups, WhatsApp - spread awareness

Competitive Landscape

Current Solutions

Public Notice Portal: Just aggregates newspaper notices. Will become obsolete when newspaper requirement ends.

Individual Council Websites: "Absolutely crap" according to Nick. "Clanky and unfriendly." No standardization, poor user experience, no representation submission.

My Platform: Complete workflow solution with council management, public engagement, and compliance built-in. First-mover advantage in the post-newspaper era.

Risk Mitigation

Technical Risks

- **Scalability:** 50,000+ notices to import, 1,500 new per day. Need to upgrade infrastructure (manageable - TypeScript/React handles this, Supabase scales).
- **OCR Accuracy:** Extracting data from PDFs needs high accuracy. Building confidence scoring and manual review for low-confidence extractions.
- **Bugs During Demos:** Current template builder has some issues. Nick advised offering free access initially so councils are forgiving of early glitches ("Show me how much money you've lost from that glitch. None? Then it's fine.").

Market Risks

- **Slow Council Adoption:** Councils are notoriously slow to change. Mitigation: Free access removes financial barrier, Nick's network provides warm introductions.
- **Legislative Changes:** Government might mandate a specific solution. Mitigation: Position as the obvious solution through early adoption and case studies.

- **Competition:** Someone else could build this. Mitigation: First-mover advantage, conference exposure this week, Nick says the people he's talking to "aren't the type to go build it themselves."

Next Steps - Prioritized Task List

PRIORITY 1 Conference Deadline (Complete by Tuesday)

1. Create landing page with QR code (mobile-optimized)
2. Record three short videos (under 2 mins total):
 - For councils: Cost savings, analytics, management features
 - For applicants: Simple process, £49.99 vs £400-600 savings
 - For public: Find notices near you, submit objections easily
3. Upload to YouTube with tracking enabled
4. Send QR codes to Nick by Monday evening

PRIORITY 2 Legal Compliance (This Week)

1. Add four licensing objectives checkboxes to objection form
2. Differentiate support vs. object submission forms
3. Add vicinity/address field to establish legitimate interest
4. Test end-to-end objection submission to council email

PRIORITY 3 Bug Fixes & Polish (This Week)

1. Fix structured template flow placeholder linking
2. Improve preview styling (currently looks basic)
3. Test opening hours copy-to-all-days functionality
4. Ensure validation shows missing fields correctly

PRIORITY 4 Council Value-Add Features (Next 2 Weeks)

1. Build analytics dashboard (total notices, by type, representation stats, geographic trends)
2. Add blue notice photo upload and tracking
3. Create representation management inbox for councils
4. Implement template builder with versioning

PRIORITY 5 Data Population (Next 2 Weeks)

1. Research legal requirements for web scraping council sites
2. Build scraping infrastructure for top 20 councils (Westminster, Lambeth, etc.)
3. Implement de-duplication and source attribution
4. Schedule automated daily scraping

Lower Priority (Next 1-3 Months)

- Expand to planning notices, traffic orders, environmental permits
- Build API for Nick's company integration
- Create cost calculator tool for councils
- Develop council onboarding process and training materials
- Security audit and penetration testing
- Mobile app development

Personal Reflections

What I'm Learning

This meeting reinforced several important lessons:

- **Adoption > Features:** Getting councils to actually use the platform is more important than building every possible feature. Free access removes the biggest barrier.
- **Positioning Matters:** Framing this as "improving democracy" and "saving taxpayer money" resonates more than technical features.
- **Network Effects:** Nick's relationships open doors I couldn't access alone. His endorsement carries weight.
- **Market Timing:** Legislative change creates urgency. The 300-year-old newspaper requirement is ending - I need to be ready when it does.
- **Forgiveness in Exchange for Free:** If I give councils free access, they'll tolerate early bugs. That removes the pressure to be perfect

before launching.

What Success Looks Like

Short-Term (Next 3 Months)

- **10 council sign-ups** from the conference and follow-up outreach
- **50+ notices published** by applicants paying £49.99
- **Case study data:** "Westminster saved £X, processed Y notices, Z representations submitted"
- **Platform stability:** No critical bugs, smooth user experience

Medium-Term (6-12 Months)

- **50+ councils using the platform**
- **500+ notices per month** = ~£25k monthly revenue
- **Expand to planning and traffic notices**
- **Recognition:** Featured in local government trade press
- **Legislative positioning:** Referenced in parliamentary discussions on digitalization

Long-Term (2-3 Years)

- **Market leader** when newspaper requirement is abolished
- **150+ councils** (40%+ market penetration)
- **£3-5M annual revenue** from applicant fees and council subscriptions
- **Platform expansion:** Scotland, Wales, potentially international markets
- **Strategic options:** Raise investment, acquire competitors, or exit to GovTech platform

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